

10 Great Dog Breeds to Own

A practical, all-round ranking for companionship - not a universal verdict. The best dog is the one whose needs, temperament and health profile fit your household.

RANK	BREED	BEST FOR	WHY IT STANDS OUT	BEFORE YOU CHOOSE
1	Labrador Retriever	Families, first-time owners	Friendly, adaptable and highly trainable; usually excellent with children and keen to join in family life.	High exercise needs; sheds heavily; choose health-tested lines.
2	Golden Retriever	Sociable, active households	Gentle, eager to please and dependable; combines easy training with an affectionate, people-focused nature.	Daily exercise and regular coat care; prone to some inherited conditions.
3	Poodle (Miniature or Standard)	Allergy-aware, engaged owners	Exceptionally intelligent, trainable and low-shedding; sizes offer flexibility for different homes.	Professional grooming and substantial mental stimulation required.
4	Cavalier King Charles Spaniel	Companionship, smaller homes	Affectionate, adaptable and typically easygoing; enjoys both lap time and moderate walks.	Screen carefully for heart, eye and neurological conditions.
5	Whippet	Calm homes, apartment living	Quiet and gentle indoors, with a short easy-care coat; energetic in bursts but often relaxed at home.	Strong chase instinct; needs secure running space and warmth in cold weather.
6	Havanese	Families wanting a small companion	Cheerful, sturdy for its size and people-oriented; trainable and generally suited to urban life.	Coat needs frequent care; can struggle when left alone for long periods.
7	English Cocker Spaniel	Active families and walkers	Merry, affectionate and responsive; a compact sporting dog that thrives on shared activities.	Needs daily exercise, ear care and consistent training; temperament varies by line.
8	Papillon	Small-home owners who enjoy training	Bright, athletic and highly trainable despite its tiny size; modest food and space requirements.	Delicate build; needs socialisation and mental activity to limit barking.
9	Bernese Mountain Dog	Experienced owners with space	Calm, affectionate and often wonderful with families; known for a gentle, steady presence.	Large, costly to keep, heavy shedding and sadly a relatively short lifespan.
10	Mixed-breed rescue	Flexible adopters	Adult temperament and size may already be clear; adoption can offer an excellent individual match and a second chance.	Background varies; use a reputable rescue that assesses behaviour and support needs.

How this list was judged: temperament, trainability, adaptability, exercise and grooming demands, and suitability for common household settings. Breed tendencies are not guarantees; individual dogs vary. Meet the dog, consider adoption, verify health testing, and budget for lifelong veterinary care. Mixed-breed rescue is included because choosing a well-assessed individual can be more useful than choosing by breed alone.